

Ambivalence, prejudice and negative behavioural tendencies towards out-groups: The moderating role of attitude basis

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Two experiments explored the relations between prejudice (suppression), (cognitive) ambivalence and negative behavioural tendencies towards out-groups. The current work argues that expressing out-group ambivalence based on cognitive, but not affective, information is a strategy to justify one's otherwise suppressed prejudice, which may ultimately "cover" the discriminatory nature of out-group-directed negative behavioural tendencies. Two experiments show that (1) participants evaluating the out-group in a normative context inducing prejudice suppression are more likely to self-report ambivalent beliefs rather than ambivalent emotions concerning the out-group as compared with participants whose prejudice expression is induced and (2) high-prejudice participants compared with low-prejudice participants are more prone to out-group-directed negative behavioural tendencies when these latter are self-reported after the expression of ambivalent beliefs but not ambivalent emotions concerning the out-group, and when the expression of their prejudicial evaluations is salient but not when it is not. In light of the extent to which ambivalent attitudes towards out-groups are often seamlessly integrated into public discourse, the implications of the findings are discussed not only for intergroup research but also at the societal level.

Keywords: Ambivalence; Prejudice; Discrimination; Attitude structure; Attitudinal basis.

People may possess attitudes that are simultaneously positive and negative. Research has found that such *ambivalence* (Scott, 1966, 1969) is an important characteristic of evaluations targeting various attitude objects (for reviews, see Jonas, Broemer, & Diehl, 2000; Thompson, Zanna, & Griffin, 1995). The present article examines attitudinal ambivalence in the domain of negative

action tendencies directed at members of groups other than ones' own. Let us explain why.

Because of its affective nature, prejudice has motivational force (Brehm, 1999; Frijda, 1986). Consistent with this notion, several researchers have stressed the importance of examining prejudice-related action tendencies because these latter constitute more proximal variables of real-world

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intergroup behaviour (e.g., Plant & Devine, 2003; Tam, Hewstone, Kenworthy, & Cairns, 2009). Indeed, prior empirical work has shown that when people meet (or even just think about) members of those groups who are the target of their prejudice, they experience an energy that can serve as a spur to negative action towards them (e.g., Brehm, 1999; Esses, Haddock, & Zanna, 1994). We believe that the investigation of ambivalence in this area is interesting for at least two reasons. First, out-group ambivalence is prominent in intergroup contexts (Katz, Wackenhut, & Hass, 1986). Additionally, there has been little emphasis in social-psychological research on the behavioural consequences of out-group ambivalence in general (see van Harreveld, van der Pligt, & de Liver, 2009), and for cross-community relations in particular. To fill in this gap in the literature, in the present work we explored the relevance of ambivalence towards out-groups in people's tendencies to behave negatively towards their members.

Prejudice expression and out-group ambivalence

The idea that individuals may express ambivalence as a way of "getting away" with the expression of otherwise suppressed prejudice is one of the tenets of the Justification-Suppression model (JSM) of prejudice expression (Crandall and Eshleman, 2003). According to it, once prejudice (a spontaneous affective reaction) is experienced, suppression factors will lead an individual not to express it in order to convince oneself or others that one is not prejudiced. However, suppression takes considerable mental energy to be enacted, thereby creating a state of tension that people are motivated to reduce. To this end, an individual will take any opportunity to express prejudicial evaluations by justifying them on some bases other than prejudice.

Among others, according to the JSM, ambivalence towards out-groups is one of such justificatory means. This idea is also consistent with the theory of aversive racism (Gaertner & Dovidio, 1986). According to this theoretical framework, group members fabricate group-neutral (i.e., non-racial) justifications for voicing their negative attitudes

towards out-groups. Thus, sheathing such attitudes in feigned positivity may be such a strategy providing a socially palatable means of providing negative information about out-groups. At the empirical level, prior research also supports the notion that out-group ambivalence can justify expression of negative attitudes. For example, Cavazza and Butera (2008) have demonstrated that people perceive expressing ambivalence as a contribution to their defence of one side or the other of a discussion issue, depending on what the specific situation requires.

The notion that people make use of ambivalence towards out-groups to manage to express their otherwise suppressed prejudice has not only intuitive appeal but also some empirical support. Yet, direct evidence of the ambivalence-prejudice expression relationship is scarce. To the best of our knowledge, only Katz and Hass (1988) and Fleming, Petty, and White (2005) directly examined the statistical association between prejudice expression and out-group ambivalence, finding a positive correlation between the two variables. Thus, we reasoned that examining whether evidence is found for this pattern of findings in more controlled research settings would be important. Specifically, this would highlight an undocumented psychological role of ambivalent attitudes towards social groups other than one's own. Accordingly, a goal of the present research was to test whether prejudice-ambivalence statistical associations can be replicated by using experimental rather than correlational research designs.

Attitudinal basis of out-group ambivalence as a moderator

Against this theoretical and empirical background, it is important to note a qualification made by the JSM. According to this model, individuals may not be always successful in expressing prejudice via ambivalence. Specifically, this would critically depend on whether the information forming ambivalent attitudes towards out-groups has an affective or a cognitive foundation (*attitudinal basis*). This notion is consistent with past theoretical work predicting that bringing to mind a given

attitude object sets off evaluative associations with valenced information differing in its affective or cognitive basis (Zanna & Rempel, 1988). Importantly, prior research has found individuals' reactions to vary depending on whether such evaluative associations are activated by emotions (an *affective* basis) or by beliefs (a *cognitive* basis) about the object's properties (e.g., Breckler, 1994; Crites, Fabrigar, & Petty, 1994; for a review, see Haddock & Zanna, 1999).

In the JSM, affectively based out-group ambivalence is defined as a conflict between the negative emotions elicited by out-groups (i.e., prejudice) and the positive emotions that serve as their suppressors. In other words, since the model defines prejudice as unambivalently negative feelings, affective out-group ambivalence is by definition bound to suppressed prejudicial attitudes. Therefore, in the JSM, the expression of affect-based out-group ambivalence is viewed as lacking the potential to justify prejudice. However, ambivalence may also be a conflict between the positive and negative beliefs about the attributes of out-group members. In the JSM, cognitively based out-group ambivalence is defined as a "stable interlocking set of beliefs that allows some kinds of release from the otherwise stymied emotional expression" (Crandall & Eshleman, 2003, p. 434). In other words, unlike affect-based out-group ambivalence, the JSM views cognitively based out-group ambivalence as being capable at justifying the expression of prejudice. Importantly, this prediction is also consistent with the Function-Structure model (FSM) of attitudes (Maio & Olson, 2000), which proposes that in general the differential predictive power of cognition-based vs. affect-based attitude components reflects the extent to which each component contains information that is relevant to the situational goal. Specifically, for research participants asked to fulfil an intergroup evaluation task, such goal will be that of establishing positive distinctiveness of the in-group over the out-group via evaluative intergroup differentiation (Tajfel, 1978; Tajfel & Turner, 1979, 1986). More specifically, the view of cognitively based out-group ambivalence as being capable at justifying the expression of prejudice is consistent with Maio and colleagues'

argument (Maio, Greenland, Bernard, & Esses, 2001) that holding an attitude towards the members of a given group that is simultaneously positive and negative may be regarded as a defensible, balanced and realistic reaction to one's appraisal of both the positive and the negative stereotypic traits of that out-group. In the same vein, some theoretical work suggests that ambivalent stereotypes of groups may legitimise prejudice. For example, Fiske, Cuddy, Glick, and Xu (2002; also see Bergsieker, Leslie, Constantine, & Fiske, 2012) have proposed that most out-groups will be targeted by some form of ambivalent derogation (e.g., being viewed as simultaneously incompetent and sociable) that may serve to legitimise prejudice and discrimination against their members. Similarly, Jost and Kay (2005) have argued that ambivalent stereotypes may contribute to system justifying beliefs that the *status quo* is fair, thereby perpetuating existing intergroup differences in status and power.

Surprisingly, however, although this theoretical work supports the argument put forth in the JSM that cognitive out-group ambivalence may justify the expression of prejudice, prior research to our knowledge has not demonstrated its empirical tenability.

The present research

In sum, the current work explores the relations between prejudice (suppression), (cognitive) ambivalence and negative behavioural tendencies towards out-groups. In an initial study we predicted that only the suppression, and not the expression, of prejudice would determine an increased formation of cognitive ambivalence, as compared with affective ambivalence, while self-reporting attitudes towards the out-group. After this, in a second study we predicted that only when people are aware, and not when they are unaware, of the fact that their prejudice is being assessed, after expressing cognitive but not affective out-group ambivalence, prejudice will be a positive predictor of out-group-directed negative action tendencies. Earlier research indeed has shown that people may build a repository of non-prejudiced self-images in order to justify and permit their discriminatory

behaviour in the future (e.g., Monin & Miller, 2001; Swim, Aikin, Hall, & Hunter, 1995), and Study 2 would help integrate the predicted pattern of findings in Study 1 with that literature. Importantly, however, we expected to find the predicted empirical pattern above only at higher levels of prejudice. In particular, we reasoned that when a justification for the expression of prejudice towards a given out-group is present (i.e., cognitive ambivalence towards that out-group is self-reported), this may cover the prejudicial roots of subsequent negative behaviour directed at the members of that group. Conceivably, the motivation to attain consistency between one's attitude and behaviour (negative evaluation and action tendency) is stronger to the extent that the attitude object (the out-group) is more self-relevant. As a consequence, we expected that after having prejudice made salient people will express cognitive ambivalence especially if they are high in prejudice. In sum, we predicted that after self-reporting cognitive but not affective out-group ambivalence, salient but not non-salient prejudice should be a positive predictor of negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group at higher levels of prejudice, whereas this should not be the case at lower levels of prejudice.

STUDY 1

Drawing on the JSM, Study 1 examined the role of cognitively based ambivalence towards out-groups in the motivated process of expressing one's otherwise suppressed prejudice. Prior research has shown that self-reported prejudice is positively related with the normative acceptability of prejudice against specific groups ($r = .96$; Crandall, Eshleman, & O'Brien, 2002). This suggests that manipulating the perceived acceptability of prejudice may alter self-reported prejudice—an experimental procedure successfully used in prior prejudice research (e.g., Blanchard, Crandall, Brigham, & Vaughn, 1994; Stangor, Sechrist, & Jost, 2001).

In the current study, we made use of this suggestion in devising our experimental manipulation of the perceived acceptability of prejudice

expression. Specifically, in line with prior theoretical work (e.g., Pettigrew, 1991) and evidence (e.g., Blanchard et al., 1994) that people follow norms regarding the expression of prejudice, we expected endorsement of a "local" norm proscribing prejudice expression to affect subsequent out-group ambivalence. As a result, under conditions of such a "local" norm made salient to the participants allocated to this experimental condition, participants should be motivated to express prejudice by means of out-group ambivalence. In contrast, because a "local" norm not explicitly proscribing prejudice expression does not constitute a normative constraint enforcing prejudice suppression, participants' endorsement of such a norm should not influence subsequent out-group ambivalence. Accordingly, under conditions of such a "local" norm made salient to the participants allocated to this experimental condition, participants should not be motivated to express prejudice by means of out-group ambivalence.

Additionally, we used an experimental manipulation to increase the salience of the cognitive and affective basis of the ambivalent attitude towards out-group members that participants were asked to self-report. Conceivably, experiencing ambivalence as cognition-based or affect-based depends on whether the informational basis of one's own ambivalent attitude is sufficiently salient (Priester & Petty, 1996, 2001). Accordingly, more conclusive support for the proposed arguments would be obtained if under conditions of a "local" norm proscribing prejudice expression (i.e., normatively enforcing prejudice suppression), cognitively based out-group ambivalence is stronger than affectively based out-group ambivalence. Consistent with the JSM, under conditions of a normative context proscribing prejudice expression, we expected this to be the case because cognitive but not affective out-group ambivalence should contribute to respond consistently with the motivation to express one's otherwise suppressed prejudice.

In contrast, more conclusive support for the proposed arguments would also be obtained if under conditions of a normative context not explicitly proscribing prejudice expression (i.e., normatively *not* enforcing its suppression), no

difference is found in cognitively based compared with affectively based out-group ambivalence. Again consistent with the JSM, we expected this to be the case because neither cognitive nor affective out-group ambivalence should contribute to respond consistently with the motivation to express one's otherwise suppressed prejudice under conditions of a normative context not explicitly proscribing prejudice expression.

Method

Participants and design

Seventy-three students (40 women; age: $M = 19.63$, $SD = 1.23$) at the University of Trento, Italy, volunteered to take part in the experiment. Participants were randomly assigned to one of the two experimental conditions manipulating the normative context of expression of their prejudice towards the out-group. However, participants belonging to each of these groups were randomly assigned to one of the two experimental conditions manipulating the basis of the ambivalent attitude towards the out-group that they were asked to self-report via a priming procedure. In sum, the full experiment was a 2 (normative context of prejudice expression: proscribed vs. non-proscribed) $\times$ 2 (attitudinal basis of out-group ambivalence: cognitive vs. affective) between-participants design. The dependent measure was ambivalence towards the out-group [*Roma* ("Gypsies")— a social group that is currently the target of fairly strong prejudicial attitudes in all European countries].

Preliminary analyses revealed no significant main effect for participant gender on any of the dependent measures, nor did it moderate any of the reported effects (all $F_s < 3.26$, ns). Thus, we do not discuss this variable further.

Procedure

Before the start of a regular lecture, an experimenter invited students to volunteer to participate in the study. Subsequently, all respondents received a questionnaire with a standardised introduction presenting the study as part of a larger research project investigating European students' attitudes

towards various issues. As a cover story, participants were told that the current questionnaire would be focused on their attitudes towards ethnic groups in their native country.

Immediately afterwards, participants were divided into two conditions differing in the normative context of prejudice expression that they induced. To this end, in the questionnaire, the participants in each of these conditions read about an allegedly current in-group norm that varied in its content. Specifically, in the prejudice-*proscribed* condition, half of the participants read a direct request to complete the tasks "in line with the widespread societal agreement (according to recent research results) with the evaluative standard prescribing that one should not favour members of one's own ethnic group over people of other ethnic groups when evaluating them on the basis of their characteristics and actions". In the prejudice-*non-proscribed* condition, the other half of the participants read a direct request to complete the tasks "in line with the widespread societal agreement (according to recent research results) with the evaluative standard prescribing that one should evaluate people irrespective of whether they belong to one's own or other ethnic groups but rather only on the basis of their characteristics and actions".

Then, the manipulation of ambivalence basis was introduced. To this end, half of the participants who were assigned to each of the normative context of prejudice expression conditions were assigned to a condition where cognitively based ambivalence towards the out-group was primed, whereas the other half of the participants was primed with affectively based ambivalence towards the out-group. The prime consisted in evoking in one condition an ambivalent attitude that was based on out-group-related cognitions but not emotions [*Thinking about Roma* ("Gypsies"), *focus on your positive and negative opinions and ideas about them*), or vice versa in the other experimental condition (*Thinking ... feelings and emotions about them*). Subsequently, all participants expressed their ambivalence towards the out-group (the dependent measure). Then, the manipulation checks of norm relevance of prejudice expression and ambivalence basis followed. Finally, participants provided

demographic data. After the data were collected, participants were debriefed.

Measures

Unless otherwise mentioned, all ratings were made on 7-point Likert-type scales ranging from 1 (*not at all*) to 7 (*very much*).

Out-group ambivalence

All participants were asked to respond to one of two different blocks of questions. Each block contained either the cognition-based or the affect-based measures of ambivalence developed by Priester and Petty (1996). Specifically, one block consisted of three items measuring cognition-based ambivalence towards the out-group (*Thinking about Roma, to what extent are your opinions/ideas/beliefs about them conflicted?*). The other block consisted of three items measuring affectively based ambivalence towards the out-group (*Thinking about Roma, to what extent are your feelings/emotions/sensations about them conflicted?*). As noted by Priester and Petty (1996), these two measures are particularly appropriate to assess the cognition-based and affect-based experience of ambivalence because of their correspondence to the commonly accepted tripartite model of attitudes (Ostrom, 1969). Indices of cognition-based or affect-based ambivalence (depending on experimental conditions) were computed by averaging participants' ratings for the items (cognition-based out-group ambivalence: $\alpha = .85$; affect-based out-group ambivalence: $\alpha = .80$). Participants' scores on this measure were examined as a dependent variable.

Norm relevance manipulation check

Participants had to answer the question *As you were completing the above tasks, to what extent did you feel as relevant the standard prescribing that one should not favour members of one's own over those belonging to other ethnic groups when evaluating them on the basis of their characteristics and actions?*

Ambivalence basis manipulation check

Participants had to answer the question *To what extent did you feel that the attitude concerning positive and negative sides of Roma you were asked to express regarded your feelings and emotions or your opinions and ideas?* All ratings were made on one bipolar 6-point scale with no neutral point, ranging from 1 (*it regarded much more my feelings and emotions than my opinion and ideas*) to 6 (*it regarded much more my opinion and ideas than my feelings and emotions*).

Results and discussion

Norm relevance manipulation check

First, we performed an analysis of variance (ANOVA) on the measure of the extent to which participants had perceived the content of the norm of prejudice suppression that was made salient to them as being relevant as they were completing the evaluation task, using normative context of prejudice expression manipulation (non-proscribed vs. proscribed condition) and basis of out-group ambivalence manipulation (cognitive vs. affective condition) as independent variables. This analysis revealed a significant main effect for normative context of prejudice expression manipulation, $F(1, 72) = 5.48, p < .05$, and no other statistically significant main or interaction effects, $F_s < 0.35$. Participants in the proscribed condition ($M = 3.46, SD = 1.17$) perceived to a significantly greater extent that the content of the norm proscribing prejudice expression (i.e., enforcing its suppression) was relevant, compared with participants in the non-proscribed condition ($M = 2.26, SD = 1.13$). This confirmed that the manipulation of the normative context of participants' expression of their prejudice had the desired effect.

Ambivalence basis manipulation check

Then, we performed an ANOVA on the measure of the extent to which participants had perceived the ambivalent attitude that they were asked to express as evoking out-group-related cognitions or

emotions, testing the same causal model as in the previous analysis. We found a significant main effect for basis of out-group ambivalence manipulation, $F(1, 72) = 5.61$, $p < .05$, and no other statistically significant main or interaction effects, $F_s < 0.88$. Participants in the cognitive ambivalence condition perceived that the ambivalent out-group attitude was more based on cognitions rather than emotions ($M = 5.35$, $SD = 1.16$), as opposed to participants in the affective ambivalence condition, who rated that attitude as being more based on emotions rather than cognitions ($M = 1.46$, $SD = 1.19$). This confirmed that the manipulation of the basis of out-group ambivalence had the desired effect.

Out-group ambivalence

Out-group ambivalence scores were analysed using a normative context of prejudice expression (non-proscribed = -1 vs. proscribed = 1) $\times$ basis of out-group ambivalence (cognitive = -1 vs. affective = 1) between-participants ANOVA. The analysis revealed no statistically significant effects, $F_s(1, 72) < 0.18$, except for the expected interaction between normative context of prejudice expression and ambivalence basis, $F(1, 72) = 5.16$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = .07$. Follow-up simple-effects analyses revealed that, among participants in the prejudice expression-proscribed (i.e., prejudice suppression) condition, ambivalence towards the out-group was stronger for those that were primed with cognitively based ambivalence compared with those that were primed with affectively based ambivalence ($M_s = 4.71$ and 3.75 , $SD_s = 1.32$ and 0.78 , respectively), $F(1, 72) = 8.72$, $p < .005$, $\eta^2 = .14$. By contrast, among participants in the prejudice expression-non-proscribed (i.e., prejudice expression) condition, ambivalence towards the out-group was not significantly different for those that were primed with cognitively based ambivalence compared with those that were primed with affectively based ambivalence ($M_s = 3.75$ and 4.41 , $SD_s = 1.89$ and 0.93 , respectively), $F(1, 72) = 1.08$, ns.

Thus, consistent with the JSM, Study 1 showed that after normative suppression but not expression of prejudice, ambivalence regarding

out-group-related beliefs is stronger than ambivalence regarding out-group-related emotions.

STUDY 2

So far we have found that justification for prejudice via cognitive ambivalence towards the out-group allows for the expression of prejudice, whereas affective out-group ambivalence does not. The goal of Study 2 was to examine the behavioural consequences of the justificatory potential of cognitive out-group ambivalence for expressing prejudice. To this end, we extended the predictions of the JSM regarding such justificatory potential of ambivalence from negative out-group attitudes (prejudice) to out-group-directed negative behaviour (negative action tendencies). In particular, we reasoned that providing a justification for the expression of prejudice towards a given out-group (i.e., after self-reporting cognitive ambivalence towards that out-group) may be perceived as covering the prejudicial roots of subsequent negative behaviour directed at the members of that group especially by individuals that are high in prejudice. Accordingly, we predicted that after self-reporting cognitive ambivalence towards that out-group, salient but not non-salient prejudice should be a positive predictor of negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group at higher levels of prejudice, whereas this should not be the case at lower levels of prejudice. By the same token, we expected that removing a justification for the expression of prejudice towards a given out-group (i.e., after self-reporting affective ambivalence towards that out-group) may be perceived as not covering the prejudicial roots of subsequent negative behaviour directed at the members of that group. As a result, we predicted that after self-reporting affective ambivalence towards the out-group, irrespective of its salience, prejudice should not predict negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group.

Method

Participants and design

Five hundred and twenty-six students (332 women; age: $M = 24.96$, $SD = 2.87$) at the University of

Trento, Italy, volunteered to take part in the experiment. Participants were randomly assigned to one of two experimental conditions manipulating the salience of one's own expression of prejudicial attitudes towards the out-group. In addition, as in Study 1, participants belonging to each of these groups were randomly assigned to one of two experimental conditions manipulating the basis of the ambivalent attitude towards the out-group that they were asked to self-report via the same priming procedure as in the preceding study. In sum, the full experiment was a 2 (prejudice expression: salient vs. non-salient) $\times$ 2 (basis of out-group ambivalence: cognitive vs. affective) between-participants design. The dependent variable was negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group (i.e., African immigrants in Italy as a general category—a particularly salient social group because of the harsh political debate and local intergroup conflicts that a newly implemented immigration law has generated in the country).

Preliminary analyses revealed no significant main effects for participant gender on any of the dependent measures, nor did it moderate any of the reported effects ($F_s < 3.11$, ns). Thus, we do not discuss this variable further.

Procedure

Participants were approached during regular lectures, and asked to volunteer to participate in the study. Subsequently, all participants received a questionnaire with a standardised introduction presenting the study as part of a larger research project investigating European students' attitudes towards various issues. As a cover story, participants were told that the current questionnaire would be focused on their attitudes towards immigrants in their native country.

In the questionnaire, at the onset all participants were given an opportunity to express their prejudice towards the target out-group. However, for half of the participants prejudice expression was salient, whereas for the other half it was not (see below, for details on the manipulation). Then, the manipulation of out-group ambivalence basis was introduced. To this end, half of the

participants who were assigned to each of the salience of prejudice expression conditions were assigned to a condition where cognitively based ambivalence towards the out-group was primed, whereas the other half of the participants was primed with affectively based ambivalence towards the out-group. The prime consisted in evoking in one condition an ambivalent attitude that was based on out-group-related cognitions but not emotions (*"Thinking about African immigrants in Italy, focus on your positive and negative opinions and ideas about them"*), or vice versa in the other experimental condition (*"Thinking ... feelings and emotions about them"*). Subsequently, all participants expressed their negative actions tendencies towards the out-group (the dependent measure). Then, the manipulation checks of salience of prejudice expression and ambivalence basis followed. Finally, participants provided demographic data. After the data were collected, participants were debriefed.

Measures

Unless otherwise mentioned, all ratings were made on 7-point Likert-type scales ranging from 1 (*not at all*) to 7 (*very much*).

Prejudice

Participants were asked to answer a modified version of the General Evaluation Scale (Wright, Aron, McLaughlin-Volpe, & Rott, 1997). Specifically, they were asked to describe how they felt about members of the in-group and the out-group by using an eight-item scale (*cold, warm, positive, negative, negative, friendly, contempt, respect*). Each of the items was administered to participants on a 6-point bipolar scale with no neutral point that allowed the direct expression of prejudice, ranging from -3 (*it applies much more to Italians than African immigrants*) to $+3$ (*it applies much more to African immigrants than Italians*). A principal components analysis was used to determine the dimensions underlying the items comprising the scale. A one-factor solution was obtained which accounted for 76% of the variance in participants'

responses (factor loadings after Promax rotation $> .79$). Consistent with that, a composite scale score was created by averaging ratings across items ($M = 4.65$, $SD = 0.46$). The scale was internally consistent ($\alpha = .82$).

In the non-salient prejudice expression condition, following prior prejudice research (e.g., Dhont, Roets, & van Hiel, 2011), the prejudice scale items were embedded in a 30-item scale concerning various political opinions, in order to reduce the obviousness of the items' association with prejudicial attitudes towards the out-group. In the salient prejudice expression condition, prejudice was assessed after the 24 items regarding political opinions. Importantly, prior to completing the prejudice items, participants in this condition read in the questionnaire *Please answer the following questions regarding how you evaluate African immigrants living in Italy with respect to Italians* in order to maximise the salience of their subsequent prejudice expression.

Out-group ambivalence

Participants were asked to answer the same scales that were used in Study 1, as adapted for the current out-group. Indices of cognition-based or affect-based ambivalence (depending on experimental conditions) were computed by averaging participants' ratings for the items (cognition-based out-group ambivalence: $\alpha = .82$, $M = 3.49$, $SD = 0.76$; affect-based out-group ambivalence: $\alpha = .82$; $M = 2.28$, $SD = 0.49$).

Negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group

Measures of "aggressive" and "avoidant" behavioural tendencies towards the out-group were adapted from Mackie, Devos, and Smith (2000). They consisted of *oppose them*, *argue with them* and *confront them*, and *keep them at distance*, *avoid them* and *have nothing to do with them*, respectively. Participants were asked to describe their usual reaction to members of the out-group. Thus, they were asked to rate each action tendency on a 6-point bipolar scale with no neutral point, ranging from -3 (*it applies much more to Italians*

than African immigrants) to $+3$ (*it applies much more to African immigrants than Italians*). A principal components analysis revealed a one-factor solution that accounted for 79% of the variance (factor loadings after Promax rotation $> .80$). Consistent with that, a composite scale score was created by averaging responses across "aggressive" and "avoidant" behavioural tendency items into an overall out-group-directed negative behavioural tendencies index ($\alpha = .86$; $M = 5.88$, $SD = 0.88$). Participants' scores on this measure were examined as a dependent variable.

Prejudice salience manipulation check

Participants had to answer the question *As you were completing the above tasks, to what extent did you feel that they regarded whether you are equally concerned for African immigrants living in Italy as for Italians?*

Ambivalence basis manipulation check

Participants were asked to answer the same scale that was used in Study 1, as adapted for the current out-group.

Results and discussion

Prejudice salience manipulation check

We performed an ANOVA on the measure of the extent to which participants had perceived their expression of prejudice as being salient as they were completing the task, using salience of prejudice expression manipulation (salient vs. non-salient) and basis of out-group ambivalence manipulation (cognitive vs. affective) as independent variables. This analysis revealed a significant main effect for salience of prejudice expression manipulation, $F(1, 525) = 7.64$, $p < .05$, and no other statistically significant main or interaction effects, $F_s < 0.56$. Participants in the salient prejudice expression condition ($M = 4.42$, $SD = 1.54$) perceived to a significantly greater extent the expression of their prejudice as being salient, compared with participants in the non-salient prejudice expression condition ($M = 2.14$, $SD = 1.23$). This confirmed that

the manipulation of the salience of prejudice expression had the desired effect.

Ambivalence basis manipulation check

Then, we performed an ANOVA on the measure of the extent to which participants had perceived the ambivalent out-group attitude that they were asked to express as evoking cognitions or emotions, testing the same model as in the previous analysis. We found a significant main effect for basis of out-group ambivalence manipulation, $F(1, 525) = 9.00, p < .05$, and no other statistically significant main or interaction effects, $F_s < 1.01$, ns. Participants in the cognitive ambivalence condition perceived that the ambivalent attitude was based on cognitions rather than emotions ($M = 4.86$, $SD = 1.05$), as opposed to participants in the affective ambivalence condition, who rated the ambivalent attitude as being based on emotions rather than cognitions ($M = 3.10$, $SD = 1.06$). This confirmed that the manipulation of the basis of out-group ambivalence had the desired effect.

Negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group

Negative behavioural tendencies scores were examined by testing a prejudice (continuous predictor) $\times$ prejudice expression salience manipulation (non-salient = -1 vs. salient = 1) $\times$ basis of out-group ambivalence (cognitive = -1 vs. affective = 1) simultaneous multiple regression model. The two categorical variables were effect-coded and the continuous one was previously mean-centred in order for the analysis to produce orthogonal rather than correlated main effects and interactions (as it would be the case by using dummy coding; Aiken & West, 1991). Preliminary addition of (cognitive or affective, depending on experimental conditions) out-group ambivalence scores as an additional mean-centred continuous predictor in the model established that out-group ambivalence did not significantly account for variance in scores of the dependent variable, t_s for main and interaction effects < 1.19 , ns. As a consequence,

out-group ambivalence was excluded from the reduced model and analyses were repeated.

These yielded no other statistically significant main effects or interactions, $t_s < |1.39|$, ns, except for the expected prejudice expression salience manipulation $\times$ basis of out-group ambivalence manipulation $\times$ prejudice interaction, $B = -0.38$, $SE = 0.15$, $t = -2.46$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = .010$ (see Figure 1). As expected, this interaction involved a reliable two-way interaction in the cognitively based ambivalence expression condition ($B = 0.26$, $SE = 0.04$, $t = 5.56$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = .13$), but not in the affectively based ambivalence expression condition ($B = 0.06$, $SE = 0.06$, $t = 1.05$, ns). Analysing the prejudice simple slopes revealed that negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group following the expression of ambivalence that was based on beliefs regarding the out-group became stronger as salient-expression prejudice increased ($B = 0.44$, $SE = 0.06$, $t = 6.49$, $p < .05$, $\eta^2 = .23$), whereas non-salient-expression prejudice was not influential in this respect ($B = -0.07$, $SE = 0.05$, $t = -1.29$, ns). Seen another way, this prejudice expression salience $\times$ prejudice interaction revealed that after self-reporting cognitively based out-group ambivalence, high-prejudice participants (analysed at 1 SD above the prejudice mean) had more negative actions tendencies towards the out-group when the previous expression of their prejudice was salient to them compared to when it was not salient ($B = 0.18$, $SE = 0.04$, $t = 3.88$, $p < .05$), whereas for low-prejudice participants (analysed at -1 SD) their negative action tendencies towards the out-group were not affected by the salience of their previously expressed prejudice ($B = -0.06$, $SE = 0.07$, $t = -0.85$, ns).

Thus, the result from Study 2 provided support for our hypothesis that for the more prejudiced but not the less prejudiced individuals, only when they are aware of the fact that their prejudice is being assessed, and not when they are unaware of it, after self-reporting ambivalence in beliefs but not emotions concerning the out-group, the behavioural tendencies towards the out-group are more negative to the extent that prejudice is greater.

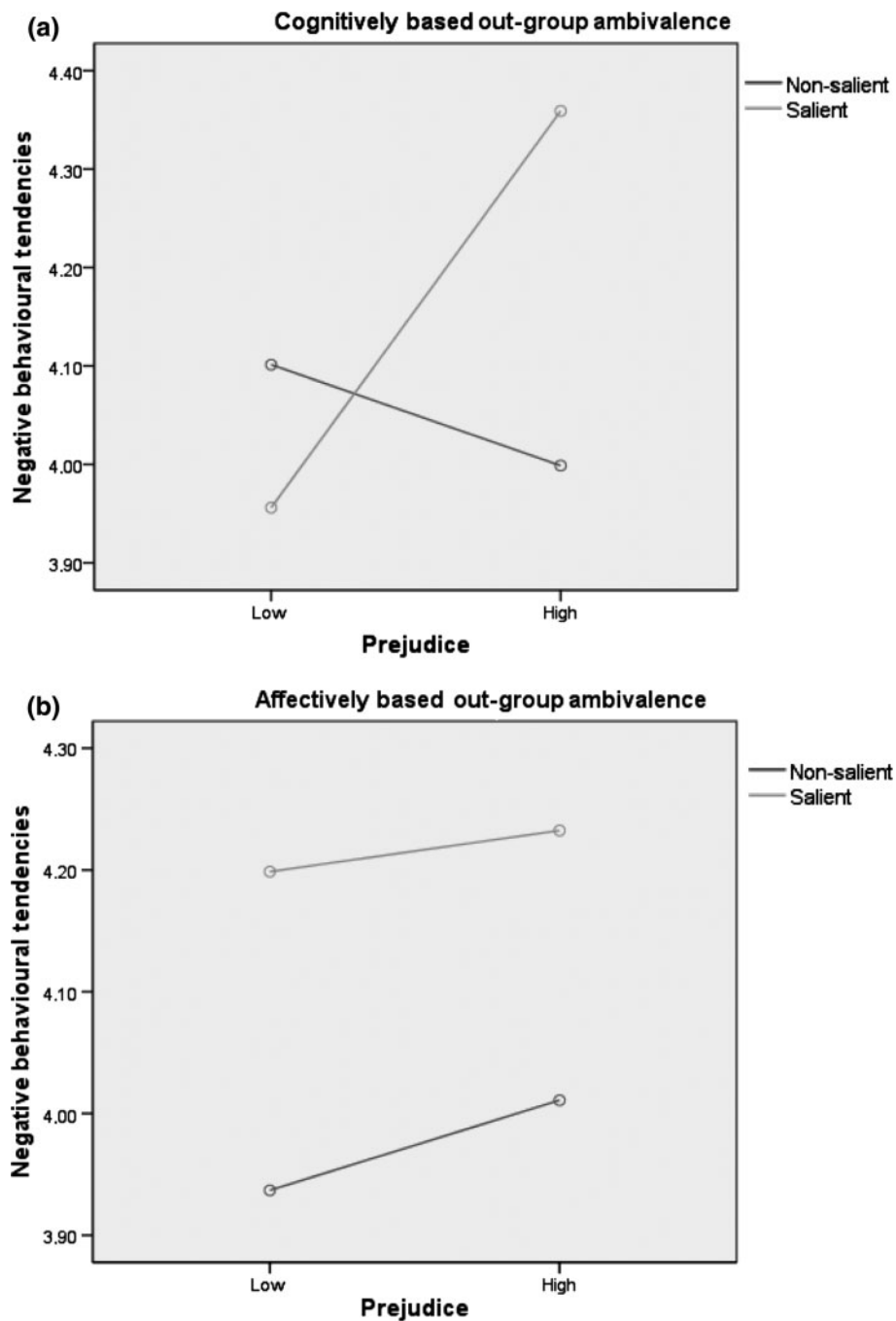


Figure 1. Negative behavioural tendencies towards the out-group in Study 2 as a function of basis of out-group ambivalence, salience of prejudice expression and prejudice level (plotted at -1 and $+1$ SD for prejudice).

GENERAL DISCUSSION

Consistent with the functional approach to the understanding of attitude structure (e.g., FSM; Maio & Olson, 2000) and intergroup ambivalence (e.g., Bergsieker et al., 2012; Fiske et al., 2002; Jost & Kay, 2005; Maio et al., 2001), we investigated the justificatory potential of out-group ambivalence for contributing to the motivated need of expressing prejudice rather than suppressing it predicted by the JSM (Crandall & Eshleman, 2003). Across two experimental studies, using different types of target groups to maximise generalisation of findings, the present work provided convergent support for the proposed framework. In Study 1, it appeared that the normative context of prejudice expression versus suppression produces conceptually consistent changes in subsequent levels of ambivalence as expected, when beliefs concerning out-group members are concerned. Specifically, we demonstrated that, after normative suppression but not expression of prejudice, ambivalence regarding out-group-related beliefs is stronger than ambivalence regarding out-group-related emotions.

While being consistent with previous correlational evidence (e.g., Fleming et al., 2005; Katz & Hass, 1988), this finding is novel in that it constitutes the first experimental demonstration of the role played by cognitive out-group ambivalence in contributing to the motivated expression of prejudice. Importantly, the results from Study 1 suggest that individuals with ambivalent beliefs about the out-group perceive such ambivalence as an attitude that others will view as being a defensible, balanced and realistic reaction to their appraisal of both the positive and the negative stereotypic traits of the out-group (Maio et al., 2001). As a consequence, this appears to provide them with sufficient “rational” justification to be overtly prejudiced. In the same vein, Study 2 demonstrated that high-prejudice compared with low-prejudice individuals are more prone to out-group-directed negative behavioural tendencies when (1) the expression of their prejudicial evaluations is salient but not when it is not and (2) their negative tendencies are self-reported after the expression of ambivalent beliefs but

not emotions concerning the out-group. Importantly, this suggests that the greater subsequent levels of tendencies in out-group-directed negative behaviour as a function of the prejudice that people experience after expressing such out-group ambivalence reflects their feeling safe at overtly showing actions consistent with a sanctioned form of out-group attitude (*being* prejudiced) that they have managed to voice in a covert way (*seeming* ambivalent).

In this regard, it is noteworthy that the above-mentioned self-licensing process constituted by expressing cognitively based out-group ambivalence is akin to that of establishing, and be liberated by, one’s “moral credentials” as non-prejudiced people that Monin and Miller (2001) recently proposed. Specifically, these researchers demonstrated that prejudiced people sometimes engage in ostensibly non-prejudiced behaviour, in order to be able to act in prejudiced manners without the fear of being morally sanctioned. However, although their psychological goal is virtually the same, these two different psychological strategies differ in their temporal application. Specifically, while “moral credentials” are established with a safeguarding effect on one’s future prejudiced acts, the behavioural evidence in the present research suggests that out-group ambivalence can reassure others of not having been prejudiced in the past, which prevents any interpretation of concurrent out-group-directed hostile action tendencies as prejudiced.

In conclusion, we have sought to demonstrate that far from the reasonable, balanced bit of cultural knowledge they are often treated as, ambivalent attitudes that are based on beliefs about out-group members may represent a clandestine means proliferating prejudicial social beliefs. Indeed, the present research shows that they are *more* likely to be expressed when prejudicial evaluations are constrained by anti-prejudice social norms (as it indeed is the case in contemporary societies; Study 1) and *more* likely to facilitate the development of hostile action tendencies for the more prejudiced individuals (Study 2). When we consider the extent to which ambivalent attitudes are often seamlessly integrated into public discourse, the implications

of these findings seem significant indeed. Previous research has noted the prevalence of ambivalent stereotypes (Fiske et al., 2002) and their potential to impact negatively members of the ambivalently stereotyped groups as well as to justify social inequality. The present research adds to this by demonstrating the extent to which ambivalent attitudes regarding stereotypic traits of out-groups may be uniquely capable at not only voicing evaluations that people eschew as prejudicial but also facilitating the development of hostile action tendencies for the more prejudiced individuals. These important negative consequences of out-group ambivalence for intergroup attitudes and behaviour may help to interpret—by uncovering their ultimate goal—the “colour-blind” stance that various xenophobic groups have adopted over the past two decades.

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